

Bogurodzica

ANONYMOUS 13th–14th century

I
B o- gu- ro- dzi- ca dzie- wi- ca, Bo- giem sławie- na Ma- ry- ja,
 U twe- go sy- na, Gospo- dzi- na, Ma- tko zwo- le- na, Ma- ry- ja!
 Zyszczy nam, spu- ści nam. Ky- ri- e e- le- i- son.
 2. Twe- go dzie- la Krzci- cie- la, bo- ży- ce, u- słysz gło- sy, na- pełń myśl- i czło- wie- cze.
 Słysz mo- dlitwę, jaż no- si- my, a dać ra- czy, je- goż pro- si- my: a na świe- cie zbożny
 po- byt, po ży- wo- cie rajski prze- byt. Ky- ri- e e- le- i- son.

TEXT AND TRANSLATION

- 1 Bogurodzica dziewica, Bogiem sławiena Maryja,
u twego syna Gospodzina matko zwolena, Maryja!
Zyszczy nam, spuści nam.
Kyrie eleison.
- 2 Twego dzieła Krzciciela, Bożyce,
usłysz głosy, napełń myśli człowiecze.
Słysz modlitwę, już nosimy,
a dać raczy, jegoż prosimy:
a na świecie zbożny pobyt,
po żywocie rajski przebyt.
Kyrie eleison.

*Mother of God, Virgin glorified by God, Mary!
Chosen Mother, Mary, from thy Son the Lord
win for us, send down to us.
Lord, have mercy.
For thy Baptist's sake, Son of God,
hear our voices, fulfil the thoughts of men.
Hear the prayer we bring,
and deign to grant what we ask:
on earth a godly life,
after life a dwelling in paradise.
Lord, have mercy.*

FOR REHEARSAL

The words. Sing the normalised text with modern Polish pronunciation, the usual practice for this song; the series pronunciation guide gives the sounds. Sing *Kyrie eleison* in seven syllables, as underlaid, with *y* as *i*.

Pitch. The written final is D. The range is a ninth, C to the D above, so the score suits most voices as written; transpose freely.

Rhythm. The manuscript gives pitches only. Sing in the rhythm of the words, with notes of roughly equal length. Sing the notes of a group on one syllable lightly and evenly, and lengthen the last note before each bar line. The pace is unhurried.

Breathing. Breathe at the full bars. The half and quarter bars mark the rhymes inside each line: a short lift, or a catch breath if needed. The double bars end each stanza.

The B on spuści. This B is natural. It is the only B in the song, at the top of the melody. Some 16th-century copies flatten B elsewhere; this version has none.

The leap at U twego. The line jumps an octave from the low D of *Maryja* to the high D. Later sources smooth it out, but it is in the oldest copy. Take it cleanly.

Forces. The song was sung in church and, by Długosz's account, by Polish knights before battle, Grunwald 1410 among them. A single voice, a small schola or a full choir in unison all suit it. One option is a cantor for each stanza with everyone joining at *Kyrie eleison*.

Both stanzas. Stanza 1 is addressed to the Virgin, stanza 2 to Christ. They share most of their music.

The score. Melody and text from the earliest notated copy, Kraków, Biblioteka Jagiellońska, MS 1619, written shortly after 1400. Text in normalised Old Polish after J. Woronczak (1962). Bar lines are editorial. For sources and variants see the critical edition.